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A REPORT ON PRACTICAL TRAINING CONDUCTED AT EAST AFRICA FOODS KINONDONI DAR ES SALAM

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ACKNOWLEDGEMENT

First and foremost, I would like to express my sincere gratitude to the Almighty God for giving me the strength, knowledge, and guidance to successfully complete my field practical training and this report. His blessings have been a source of inspiration and perseverance throughout this period.

I would like to extend my heartfelt appreciation to the management and staff of East Africa Food for welcoming me into their organization and providing me with the opportunity to gain hands-on experience. Their guidance, support, and willingness to share knowledge significantly contributed to my learning and professional growth.

My sincere thanks also go to my academic supervisor Mr.[redacted] at the Institute of Finance Management (IFM) for their continuous support, advice, and constructive feedback throughout the fieldwork and report writing process. Their guidance helped me stay focused and achieve the objectives of this practical training.

I am grateful to my family, friends, and colleagues for their moral support, encouragement, and understanding during the entire period of my attachment. Their motivation and support played a vital role in ensuring the successful completion of this practical training and report.

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LIST OF ABBREVIATIONS

AI	Artificial Intelligence
BAIT	Bachelor of Accounting with Information Technology
COSO	Committee of Sponsoring Organizations of the Treadway Commission
DTT	Double Taxation Treaty
GDP	Gross Domestic Product
HR	Human Resources
IFM	Institute of Finance Management
ICT	Information and Communication Technology
MNCs	Multinational Corporations
NYSCOS	New York State Office of the State Comptroller
SAP	Systems, Applications, and Products in Data Processing

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EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

This report presents a comprehensive overview of my field practical training conducted at East Africa Food, focusing on the tasks undertaken in the accounts department. The primary objective of the training was to bridge the gap between theoretical knowledge acquired at the Institute of Finance Management (IFM) and practical application in a real-world business environment. Key activities included preparing journals, recording sales transactions, settling debts, and performing bank reconciliations.

During the training, I gained practical skills in bookkeeping, financial recording, bank reconciliation, and internal control systems. I also enhanced analytical thinking, attention to detail, and organizational skills, which are essential for effective financial management. The experience provided exposure to the application of accounting theories such as Stewardship Theory, Accounting Information Theory, and Internal Control Theory in a real organizational context.

The practical training highlighted both strengths and areas for improvement. While I acquired essential professional skills and gained confidence in financial management tasks, I also identified gaps in advanced accounting software proficiency, taxation knowledge, financial analysis, and professional communication. These gaps will be important for my continued professional development.

Finally, the report provides recommendations to East Africa Food and IFM to enhance operational efficiency and practical training outcomes. For the organization, suggestions include investing in technology, providing employee training, and strengthening internal controls. For IFM, recommendations focus on increasing collaboration with industry partners, organizing workshops on modern accounting tools, and establishing mentorship mechanisms. The training was instrumental in developing both practical skills and career ambitions in accounting and finance.

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CHAPTER ONE

INTRODUCTION

1.1. Chapter Introduction

This chapter provides an overview of East Africa Foods, covering its background, products and services, mission, vision, core values, and primary functions. It also reviews the agribusiness industry, highlighting suppliers, customers, competitors, entry barriers, and substitute threats. The chapter outlines the purpose and process of field practical training, along with the learning objectives, providing a comprehensive context for understanding the company and practical training framework.

1.2Objective of Field Practical Training

1.2.1. The overall process/purpose of field practical training

Field practical training is designed to provide students with hands-on experience in real-world work environments, bridging the gap between theoretical knowledge and practical application. The overall process typically involves identifying suitable organizations or companies, placing students under supervision, and assigning them specific tasks aligned with their field of study. During the training, students observe and participate in day-to-day operations, engage with professionals, and apply academic concepts to solve practical problems. The purpose of field practical training is to enhance students' professional skills, including problem-solving, decision-making, communication, and teamwork. It also exposes them to industry standards, organizational structures, and workplace ethics. Ultimately, the training aims to prepare students for future employment by equipping them with practical knowledge, confidence, and the ability to adapt to dynamic work environments.

1.2.2. Learning objectives for conducting fieldwork.

- To apply theoretical knowledge in real-world organizational settings.
- To develop practical skills and gain hands-on experience in professional tasks.
- To observe and understand organizational processes, industry practices, and workplace challenges.
- To enhance critical thinking, problem-solving, and decision-making abilities.

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- To improve communication, teamwork, and professional behavior.
- To integrate academic knowledge with practical applications, preparing for future careers.

1.3. An overview of fieldwork placement

1.3.1. Background of East African Food

In Tanzania, over 48% of agricultural produce, equivalent to 4.7 million tons is wasted annually due to poor farming practices, inadequate storage, transport challenges, and limited access to markets, leaving smallholder farmers dependent on middlemen who pay them less than 25% of retail value. East Africa Foods was founded to solve this problem by directly connecting farmers with buyers through an efficient supply and demand system supported by cold chain logistics such as refrigerated trucks and storage facilities. Aggregating, processing, and distributing fresh produce, the company has tripled the annual income of more than 1,000 farmers, expanded operations with a 15,000 sq. ft. cold storage facility in Dar es Salaam, and built a strong client base that includes hotels, restaurants, vendors, and corporates. With annual revenues surpassing $1.5 million and a $2 million capital raise in 2020, East Africa Foods has established itself as the largest fresh produce aggregator and distributor in Tanzania, with a mission to reduce food waste and improve farmers' livelihoods. More than 48% of the produce grown is wasted in Tanzania, amounting to over 4.7 million tons of food that would have otherwise been income to farmers. This is due to post-harvest losses suffered by smallholder farmers resulting from poor farming, transport and storage mechanisms. Much of this is due to farmers' lack of access to markets, which makes them rely on middlemen. Usually, it takes two to three middlemen to take a kilo of produce to the market. This results in farmers getting less than 25% of the retail/market price and the rest being distributed among middlemen with no value addition. East Africa Foods connects smallholder farmers with buyers by establishing a reliable demand and supply management system, taking advantage of technology in storage and distribution.

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1.3.1.1. Products/services

Fresh Vegetables

East Africa Foods aggregates a wide range of vegetables such as tomatoes, onions, spinach, and leafy greens from smallholder farmers. These vegetables are processed and distributed through a cold chain system to maintain freshness, ensuring consistent quality for hotels, restaurants, caterers, and market vendors.

Fresh Fruits

The company supplies tropical fruits such as bananas, mangoes, pineapples, and avocados sourced directly from farmers across Tanzania. By using refrigerated trucks and cold storage facilities, East Africa Foods extends the shelf life of fruits, reducing post-harvest losses and ensuring consumers access fresh and nutritious produce.

Cold Storage Services

Beyond supplying produce, East Africa Foods provides cold storage solutions at its 15,000 square-foot facility in Dar es Salaam. This service allows for proper preservation of perishable products before distribution, minimizing waste and maintaining high quality for clients.

Distribution and Logistics

The company offers efficient distribution services using its fleet of refrigerated trucks that transport produce from collection centers to processing facilities and then to customers. This logistics service ensures timely delivery, reduces spoilage, and strengthens the overall supply chain from farmers to end markets.

1.3.1.2. Core values of East Africa Food

Integrity

The company upholds honesty and transparency in all its operations, ensuring trust between farmers, customers, and other stakeholders.

Innovation

East Africa Foods leverages technology and creative solutions such as cold chain logistics and digital platforms to address post-harvest losses and streamline the food supply chain.

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Sustainability

The company is committed to building a sustainable food system by minimizing food waste, promoting environmental responsibility, and ensuring long-term benefits for farmers and communities.

Farmer Empowerment

Supporting smallholder farmers is at the core of East Africa Foods' operations. The company ensures farmers gain fair market access, higher incomes, and improved livelihoods.

Customer Focus

East Africa Foods strives to deliver quality, fresh, and safe produce to its customers while ensuring timely supply and service satisfaction.

1.3.1.3. Mission of East Africa Food

The mission of East Africa Foods is to eliminate food waste, empower farmers, and deliver fresh, high-quality produce through sustainable and innovative supply chain solutions.

1.3.1.4. Vision of East Africa Food

The vision of East Africa Foods is to become the leading and most trusted fresh produce supply chain company in East Africa, ensuring zero food waste and thriving farming communities.

1.3.2. Primary functions of East Africa Food

Aggregation of Produce

East Africa Foods collects fresh fruits and vegetables from smallholder farmers across Tanzania. This function ensures that farmers have a reliable market for their produce. Aggregating large volumes, the company can meet the demand of diverse customers consistently.

Processing and Storage

The company operates a modern processing and cold storage facility in Dar es Salaam. This allows produce to be cleaned, sorted, and preserved under controlled conditions. As a result, the shelf life of perishable goods is extended, minimizing post-harvest losses.

Distribution and Logistics

East Africa Foods manages an efficient logistics network supported by refrigerated trucks. This ensures timely and safe delivery of fresh produce to hotels, restaurants, supermarkets, and market vendors. The system reduces spoilage during transportation and strengthens customer trust.

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Farmer Support and Empowerment

Beyond distribution, the company provides training and market access support to smallholder farmers. This empowers farmers with better skills and fair prices for their produce. Ultimately, it improves livelihoods and enhances agricultural productivity.

1.3.3. Organization structure of East Africa Food

The organization structure of East Africa Food is designed to ensure smooth operations across the entire food supply chain, from sourcing produce from smallholder farmers to processing, storage, and distribution to customers. The structure is hierarchical, with the Managing Director overseeing all departments, including Finance & Accounts, Procurement, Sales & Marketing, Production & Processing, and Logistics & Distribution. Each department plays a critical role in achieving the company's mission of reducing food waste, increasing farmers' income, and ensuring efficient delivery of fresh produce to customers.

During my practical training, I was primarily attached to the **Finance & Accounts Department**, where I gained hands-on experience in financial record-keeping, bank reconciliation, debt management, and sales transaction recording. I also had exposure to the **Sales & Marketing Department**, which allowed me to understand how sales data is captured and integrated into financial records. I briefly interacted with the **Logistics & Distribution Department** to observe how cold chain systems and inventory management practices affect financial reporting and operational efficiency.

This departmental exposure helped me understand the interdependence between different functions within the organization and how effective communication and coordination contribute to operational success. The experience reinforced the importance of accurate financial management, timely reporting, and adherence to internal control mechanisms, which are essential for maintaining the organization's integrity and performance.

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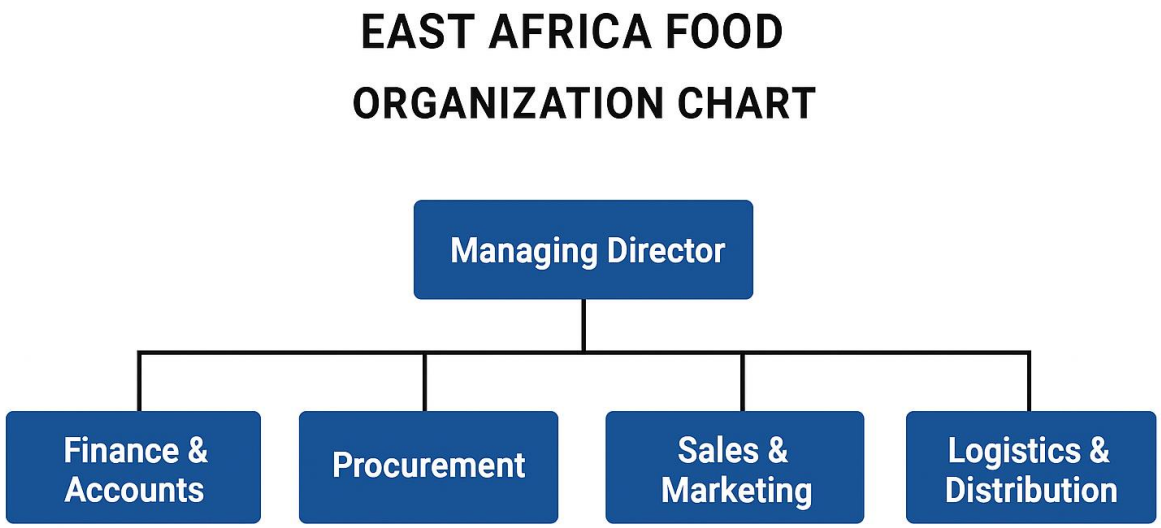


Figure 1.0 East Africa Food

1.4. Review of the industry in which the company operates

East Africa Foods operates in the agribusiness and food supply chain industry, which connects smallholder farmers with urban markets, including hotels, restaurants, supermarkets, and market vendors. The main suppliers are local farmers who provide fresh fruits and vegetables, while competitors include established players such as Twiga Foods and Tindwa, creating high competitive rivalry. The industry faces moderate to high barriers to entry due to the need for cold storage facilities, refrigerated transportation, and advanced technology, while buyers hold moderate bargaining power given their multiple sourcing options. Substitute products, such as imported frozen or canned foods, pose a significant threat, making quality and freshness critical for market competitiveness.

The industry is also influenced by political, economic, social, technological, environmental, and legal factors. Government policies on agriculture, trade, and food safety, as well as labor laws, directly impact operations. Economic growth and rising urban populations increase demand for

fresh produce, while consumer preferences for healthy, locally sourced food strengthen market opportunities. Technological advancements in cold chain logistics and mobile farm-to-market platforms enhance efficiency, whereas environmental challenges such as climate change and post-harvest losses affect supply consistency. Overall, these dynamics create both challenges and opportunities for companies like East Africa Foods to expand and maintain a strong market presence.

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CHAPTER TWO

WORK DONE AND LESSONS LEARNT

2.1. Chapter Introduction

This chapter presents a detailed account of the field practical training experience, focusing on the tasks undertaken and the lessons learned. It describes the specific activities performed during the field placement, analyzes the skills and knowledge acquired through these tasks, and highlights how practical engagement reinforced theoretical concepts. The chapter also summarizes the overall work completed, the key insights gained, and the challenges encountered during the fieldwork, providing a comprehensive reflection on the training experience and its contribution to professional development.

2.2. Description of tasks undertaken during the field

2.2.1Preparation of journal

During the field practical training, I prepared a detailed journal to document all activities, observations, and tasks performed on a daily basis. This process allowed me to systematically record the procedures followed, challenges encountered, and solutions applied in the workplace. Through maintaining the journal, I was able to reflect on my experiences, track my learning progress, and identify areas for improvement. The journal served as a reference for compiling reports and analyzing the skills and knowledge gained during the field placement.

2.2.2 Recording sales transactions

During the field practical training, I was responsible for recording sales transactions to ensure accurate financial documentation. I recorded all daily sales, including quantities sold, prices, and customer details, using the company's accounting system. This activity helped me understand the flow of revenue and the importance of maintaining accurate records for business decision-making. It also enhanced my practical skills in bookkeeping, attention to detail, and data organization, which are essential for financial management.

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2.2.3Settling debts

During the field practical training, I was involved in settling debts with suppliers and service providers to ensure smooth business operations. I reviewed outstanding balances, verified invoices, and made payments according to the company's procedures. This activity helped me understand the importance of managing liabilities and maintaining good relationships with creditors. It also improved my practical skills in financial management, record-keeping, and attention to detail.

2.2.4Preparation of bank reconciliation

During the field practical training, I prepared bank reconciliations to ensure that the company's cash records matched the bank statements. I compared the company's ledger entries with the bank transactions, identified discrepancies, and made necessary adjustments. This task helped me understand the importance of accurate financial record-keeping and detecting errors or omissions. It also enhanced my skills in attention to detail, analytical thinking, and practical accounting procedures.

2.3. Lessons learnt based on the task described above

2.3.1Preparation of Journal

Through preparing the journal, I learnt the value of systematically recording daily activities and observations. This process improved my ability to track tasks, reflect on challenges, and document solutions effectively. It also helped me organize my work and identify areas where I needed further improvement. Maintaining the journal served as a useful reference for evaluating my learning progress throughout the fieldwork.

2.3.2Recording Sales Transactions

While recording sales transactions, I gained practical skills in bookkeeping and financial documentation. I understood how accurate sales records support revenue tracking and informed business decisions. This task enhanced my attention to detail and ability to manage large volumes of data efficiently. It also reinforced the importance of consistency and accuracy in daily business operations.

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2.3.3Settling Debts

Settling debts taught me how to manage liabilities and maintain good relationships with suppliers and service providers. I learned to verify invoices carefully and make timely payments according to company procedures. This task improved my practical knowledge of financial accountability and cash flow management. It reinforced the significance of professional communication in business transactions.

2.3.4Preparation of Bank Reconciliation

Through preparing bank reconciliations, I learnt to compare company records with bank statements and identify discrepancies. This activity enhanced my analytical thinking and problem-solving skills. I understood the importance of accurate record-keeping to detect errors and prevent financial misstatements. The task also strengthened my ability to maintain reliable financial information for decision-making purposes.

2.4. Summary of the work done and lessons learnt

Table 2.0 Summary of the work done and lessons learnt

Week	Task/Activity	Lessons Learnt
Week 1	Preparation of Journal	Learnt systematic record-keeping, documenting daily activities, tracking progress, and reflection.
Week 2	Recording Sales Transactions	Enhanced bookkeeping skills, attention to detail, understanding revenue flow, and data organization.
Week 3	Settling Debts	Understood managing liabilities, verifying invoices, timely payments, and maintaining supplier relationships.
Week 4	Preparation of Bank Reconciliation	Improved analytical thinking, accuracy in financial records, error detection, and problem-solving skills.

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2.5. Challenges encountered during fieldwork

Limited Practical Exposure

At times, I faced limited practical exposure to certain advanced accounting software and procedures due to company policy restrictions. This reduced the opportunity to gain hands-on experience in all areas of accounting. However, I compensated by observing closely and asking questions to understand the processes. This taught me patience and the importance of learning through observation when direct practice is not possible.

Time Management

Managing multiple tasks within limited office hours was challenging, especially during peak periods of sales or payments. I had to prioritize activities and work efficiently to meet deadlines. This experience improved my time management and organizational skills. It also taught me the importance of planning daily tasks to ensure all responsibilities are completed on time.

Communication Barriers

Occasionally, I encountered communication barriers with suppliers or internal staff due to differences in terminologies terminology or work styles. This sometimes slowed down task completion or required repeated clarifications. I learnt to ask clear, concise questions and maintain professional communication. This improved my interpersonal skills and ability to adapt to different working environments.

Handling Large Volumes of Data

Recording and reconciling large volumes of sales and financial transactions was overwhelming at times. Ensuring accuracy while managing extensive data required high concentration and attention to detail. Through this challenge, I enhanced my data management and analytical skills. It also reinforced the importance of double-checking work to avoid errors in financial reporting.

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CHAPTER THREE

LITERATURE REVIEW

3.1. Chapter Introduction

This chapter presents a comprehensive review of literature related to bank reconciliation, highlighting its theoretical foundations, practical applications, and recent developments in the field. It examines key academic theories, including Stewardship Theory, Accounting Information Theory, and Internal Control Theory, which underpin the importance of accurate financial reporting and internal controls. The chapter also explores recent technological advancements in reconciliation, such as automation, cloud-based platforms, and AI applications, demonstrating how these developments enhance accuracy and efficiency. Furthermore, the literature is linked to the tasks undertaken during the field practical training, showing how theory aligns with practical accounting activities.

3.2. Review of literature on the bank Reconciliation

Bank reconciliation is a key accounting procedure that ensures a company's cash records match its bank statements. It involves identifying discrepancies, such as errors or omissions, and making necessary adjustments. According to Harrison and Horngren (2013), bank reconciliation helps verify the accuracy of cash balances in the general ledger and prevents financial misstatements. It is a fundamental internal control tool for maintaining accurate financial records (Harrison & Horngren, 2013).

Regular bank reconciliation enhances internal control by detecting errors and preventing fraud. According to New York State Office of the State Comptroller (2015), monthly reconciliations enable organizations to identify unauthorized transactions promptly. This process ensures accountability and strengthens trust in financial reporting. It is particularly important for organizations handling large cash volumes (NYSOSC, 2015).

Bank reconciliation also supports effective cash flow management and decision-making. Upflow (2020) notes that aligning bank statements with company records allows managers to monitor liquidity accurately. Accurate reconciliations prevent overestimating available cash and help plan

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for operational or investment needs. This ensures informed financial decisions and regulatory compliance (Upflow, 2020).

In educational settings, bank reconciliation is a practical tool for learning accounting skills. Onuoha and Amponsah (2012) assert that students practicing reconciliations gain hands-on experience in recording, analyzing, and correcting financial data. This strengthens understanding of theoretical accounting principles. Practical exercises improve analytical thinking and problem-solving skills in real-world contexts (Onuoha & Amponsah, 2012).

Bank reconciliation also contributes to financial transparency and accountability. The Washington State Auditor's Office (2018) emphasizes that reconciling accounts highlights errors, unauthorized transactions, and discrepancies between internal and bank records. Regular reconciliations enhance reliability of financial statements. They support audit processes and provide stakeholders with confidence in financial reporting (WSAO, 2018).

The process helps in fraud detection and prevention. Trovata (2021) explains that discrepancies revealed during reconciliation can signal potentially fraudulent activities. By regularly comparing internal records with bank statements, organizations can identify unusual transactions early. This serves as both a corrective and preventive measure against financial misconduct (Trovata, 2021).

Aautomation of bank reconciliation increases efficiency and reduces human error. Solvexia (2020) highlights that automated systems streamline reconciliation, allowing for faster processing and more accurate results. Automation frees up accountants to focus on analysis rather than routine data entry. It also strengthens internal controls by providing real-time visibility into cash flows and discrepancies (Solvexia, 2020).

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3.2.1. Review on the key academic theories

Stewardship Theory

The Stewardship Theory emphasizes that managers act as stewards of organizational resources, entrusted to protect and manage assets responsibly. According to Donaldson and Davis (1991), managers are expected to act in the best interest of the organization rather than pursuing personal gain. Bank reconciliation reinforces stewardship by ensuring that all cash transactions are accurately recorded. It allows for timely identification and correction of errors, preventing loss of resources. Maintaining precise records, managers demonstrate accountability and responsibility in handling organizational funds. This strengthens trust between management and stakeholders, promoting financial integrity (Donaldson & Davis, 1991).

Regular reconciliation encourages proactive management of cash resources and reduces the risk of mismanagement. Managers can use reconciliation data to make informed operational and investment decisions. The practice ensures transparency and provides evidence that resources are being properly monitored. Stewardship theory highlights the ethical obligation of managers to safeguard organizational assets. Reconciling accounts regularly, managers fulfill their fiduciary duties and demonstrate responsible financial governance. This process also contributes to the credibility of management decisions in the eyes of stakeholders (Donaldson & Davis, 1991).

Bank reconciliation allows managers to detect discrepancies, such as errors or unauthorized withdrawals, promptly. It provides a systematic approach to monitor cash flows and maintain accurate financial records. Managers are able to assess cash availability for operational needs and strategic projects. This aligns with stewardship principles, which prioritize long-term organizational health and sustainability. Regular monitoring through reconciliation fosters ethical management practices. It ensures that managers act as trustworthy custodians of organizational resources (Donaldson & Davis, 1991).

The reconciliation process enhances accountability and internal reporting accuracy. Stakeholders, including investors and creditors, gain confidence in financial statements that reflect actual cash balances. Timely reconciliation demonstrates that managers are committed to transparency and prudent financial management. The stewardship role is reinforced by the proactive identification of discrepancies. Managers can take corrective measures before issues escalate into financial

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losses. This practice supports organizational stability and efficient resource utilization (Donaldson & Davis, 1991).

Finally, stewardship theory highlights that ethical and responsible management strengthens stakeholder trust. Bank reconciliation provides tangible evidence that cash resources are protected and monitored effectively. It serves as both a preventive and corrective tool in financial management. Reconciling accounts, managers uphold the organization's ethical and fiduciary standards. This ensures sustainability, accuracy, and accountability in financial reporting. Stewardship through reconciliation thus integrates ethical responsibility with practical accounting practices (Donaldson & Davis, 1991).

The Accounting Information Theory

The Accounting Information Theory emphasizes the reliability and relevance of financial information for decision-making. According to Scott (2015), accurate financial records are essential for managers, investors, and other stakeholders. Bank reconciliation ensures that cash balances in accounting records align with actual bank statements. This guarantees that financial information reflects the organization's real cash position. Accurate reconciliations allow for informed operational and strategic decisions. Reliable information is the foundation for effective financial planning and control (Scott, 2015).

Reconciliation helps maintain the integrity of financial data by identifying errors or omissions. Discrepancies such as unrecorded deposits, bank charges, or unauthorized withdrawals can distort accounting records. Scott (2015) emphasizes that inaccurate information reduces the usefulness of financial reports for decision-making. Regular reconciliation ensures that reported cash balances are complete and reliable. This improves managers' ability to plan budgets, control costs, and manage cash flows. Accurate financial information supports transparency and accountability in organizational operations (Scott, 2015).

The process also facilitates timely financial analysis and reporting. Accurate reconciled information allows managers to track liquidity and operational cash requirements. It prevents overestimation or underestimation of cash, which could lead to misinformed decisions. The Accounting Information Theory highlights that relevance and reliability of information are key for effective management. Bank reconciliation ensures that financial decisions are based on verified

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data. This practice enhances confidence in both internal management and external stakeholders (Scott, 2015).

Bank reconciliation contributes to operational efficiency by providing clear records for audits and financial reviews. Stakeholders can rely on reconciled statements for accurate assessment of organizational performance. Accurate financial information allows for better forecasting and financial planning. According to Scott (2015), reliable accounting information reduces the risk of financial mismanagement. Reconciling accounts regularly, managers ensure that cash records are precise. This enhances decision-making quality across all levels of management (Scott, 2015).

Finally, reconciled financial data enhances compliance with accounting standards and regulations. Organizations demonstrate accountability by maintaining correct cash balances. Stakeholders are reassured that management decisions are grounded in accurate information. Regular reconciliation aligns with the principles of the Accounting Information Theory by providing reliable, relevant, and timely data. It strengthens the organization's financial credibility and operational efficiency. Ultimately, bank reconciliation ensures that decision-making is based on trustworthy information (Scott, 2015).

The Internal Control Theory

The Internal Control Theory emphasizes procedures and mechanisms to safeguard assets, prevent fraud, and ensure accuracy in financial reporting. According to COSO (2013), effective internal controls protect organizational resources and improve operational efficiency. Bank reconciliation is a direct application of this theory as it compares cash records with bank statements. Discrepancies are promptly detected, preventing misappropriation of funds. This enhances the reliability of financial reporting and maintains stakeholder confidence. Reconciliation serves as both a preventive and detective control mechanism (COSO, 2013).

Bank reconciliation ensures that all cash inflows and outflows are accurately recorded. It detects unauthorized or erroneous transactions, reducing financial risk. COSO (2013) emphasizes that internal controls, such as reconciliation, are essential to prevent fraud and errors. Regular reconciliations verify that cash balances in the general ledger reflect the actual bank position. This strengthens the organization's control environment and supports compliance with regulatory standards. Accurate cash records also facilitate auditing and operational decision-making (COSO, 2013).

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The process also promotes accountability among staff handling financial transactions. Reconciliation requires verification of deposits, payments, and adjustments, ensuring responsibility for accurate recording. COSO (2013) notes that proper internal controls reduce the likelihood of financial misstatements. Bank reconciliation provides documentation and evidence for audit trails. It reinforces ethical behavior in financial management and ensures adherence to company policies. This supports the organization's overall governance framework and operational integrity (COSO, 2013).

Bank reconciliation contributes to efficient cash management and operational oversight. Regularly comparing ledger entries with bank statements, managers can detect anomalies early. This allows timely corrective actions and prevents financial losses. COSO (2013) highlights that continuous monitoring of assets is central to internal control theory. Reconciliation supports risk management by identifying vulnerabilities in cash handling. It also strengthens the reliability of financial reporting, which is essential for decision-making and stakeholder confidence (COSO, 2013).

Finally, the Internal Control Theory links reconciliation to overall organizational efficiency. Reconciled accounts ensure that financial statements are accurate and credible. This prevents errors, fraud, and financial mismanagement. COSO (2013) states that internal control mechanisms like reconciliation are critical for achieving financial accountability and operational effectiveness. Integrating reconciliation into daily operations, organizations safeguard assets and improve transparency. The practice ensures accurate reporting and reinforces trust among management, auditors, and stakeholders (COSO, 2013).

3.2.2. Knowledge of the student in the area reviewed is up to date

3.2.2 Demonstrating Up-to-Date Knowledge in Bank Reconciliation

Recent developments in bank reconciliation emphasize automation and integration with digital accounting systems. Modern accounting software, such as QuickBooks, Xero, and Trovata, allows real-time reconciliation of bank statements with ledger accounts, reducing human error and saving time (Trovata, 2021). Cloud-based platforms have further enabled remote access to financial records, facilitating continuous monitoring of cash transactions. Artificial Intelligence (AI) and Machine Learning (ML) are increasingly being applied to detect anomalies and flag suspicious transactions automatically. Furthermore, integration with payment gateways allows automatic matching of incoming payments with invoices, enhancing accuracy and efficiency. These

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developments show that bank reconciliation is evolving from a manual, periodic task to a continuous, automated control process, reflecting the current trends in financial management (Solvexia, 2020).

The adoption of digital reconciliation tools also improves compliance and audit readiness. Automated systems generate detailed audit trails and reports, which support regulatory and internal audits (COSO, 2013). Businesses are now able to reconcile multiple accounts simultaneously, across different currencies and banks, improving scalability for larger organizations. Blockchain technology is also being explored as a method to enhance transparency and security in financial transactions. These advancements indicate that the field of bank reconciliation is dynamic, with technology significantly improving reliability, speed, and decision-making. Continuous learning and adaptation to these tools are essential for students and practitioners in accounting.

3.2.3 Related Literature Review with Tasks Undertaken

The reviewed literature closely aligns with the tasks I performed during field practical training in the accounts department. For instance, the preparation of journals, as emphasized by Accounting Information Theory (Scott, 2015), is critical for accurate record-keeping and ensures that cash entries are correctly documented. Recording sales transactions reflects principles from the Stewardship Theory (Donaldson & Davis, 1991), as it demonstrates responsible handling of organizational resources. Settling debts relates to Internal Control Theory (COSO, 2013), as it ensures liabilities are managed and financial integrity is maintained.

Preparing bank reconciliations directly applies the theories and literature discussed, by verifying that ledger balances match bank statements. Literature emphasizes the importance of detecting discrepancies, preventing fraud, and maintaining reliable financial information (Harrison & Horngren, 2013; NYSOSC, 2015). Performing these tasks, I was able to link theory with practice, observing firsthand how reconciliation processes reinforce ethical management, enhance accuracy, and support decision-making. The experience demonstrates that contemporary accounting literature and practical applications are complementary, preparing students to apply updated knowledge in real-world scenarios.

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CHAPTER FOUR

ANALYSIS

4.1. Chapter Introduction

This chapter presents a detailed analysis of the practical experiences gained during the field attachment. It highlights the tasks undertaken, the skills learned and enhanced, and how these experiences relate to theories studied in class. The chapter also evaluates the impact of the training on my career ambitions, identifies skills that are lacking, and discusses challenges encountered. It provides a comprehensive reflection on the learning outcomes and practical exposure acquired during the fieldwork.

4.2. Relation on theories learnt in class with what is happening in the market

The **Stewardship Theory** emphasizes that managers act as responsible custodians of organizational resources, ensuring that assets are protected and financial information is accurate (Donaldson & Davis, 1991). During my field practical training, I observed that preparing journals and recording sales transactions directly reflected stewardship principles. In theory, managers are expected to maintain meticulous records and prevent misuse of resources. In practice, while the company had a well-structured system for documenting transactions, occasional delays in data entry showed a slight gap between theoretical expectations and operational reality. Nonetheless, proper supervision and review mechanisms helped maintain accountability and trust.

Accounting Information Theory highlights the importance of reliable and relevant financial data for decision-making (Scott, 2015). In class, it is emphasized that bank reconciliation should always reflect actual cash balances. During fieldwork, preparing bank reconciliations allowed me to identify timing differences and unrecorded transactions, which could have led to inaccurate financial reporting. While textbooks assume ideal conditions with timely updates and complete data, the real market scenario often involves delays and adjustments. This shows how theoretical reliability standards are challenged by practical realities, emphasizing the need for consistent monitoring and data verification.

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The **Internal Control Theory** focuses on safeguarding assets, preventing fraud, and improving reporting accuracy (COSO, 2013). Literature suggests that regular reconciliation acts as a preventive and detective control. In practice, while settling debts and reconciling bank statements, I observed that the company followed procedures to verify invoices and track payments. This ensured that cash outflows were properly documented and liabilities were managed. However, the reliance on manual cross-checking sometimes slowed the process, demonstrating the gap between ideal internal controls suggested in theory and the time constraints faced in real-world operations.

Technological advancements in the market are helping bridge the gap between theory and practice. The literature advocates for accuracy, timeliness, and efficiency in reconciliation (Trovata, 2021; Solvexia, 2020). The company's gradual adoption of digital accounting tools for record-keeping and transaction matching improved accuracy, reduced errors, and minimized time delays. This illustrates that while classical theories provide the foundational principles, modern tools help align practice with theoretical standards by automating repetitive tasks and enhancing data reliability.

Comparing theoretical frameworks with practical operations shows both alignment and areas for improvement. Stewardship, accounting information, and internal control theories provide ideal standards for financial management. Field observations reveal that while companies largely adhere to these principles, operational realities such as manual processes, time delays, and data entry errors can create gaps. The integration of technology, continuous monitoring, and proper supervision is essential to ensure that market practices reflect the expectations outlined in literature and textbooks.

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4.3. Description of skills learned and enhanced

During the field practical training, I developed and enhanced a range of practical and professional skills essential for accounting and financial management. First, **bookkeeping and financial recording skills** were strengthened through preparing journals, recording sales transactions, and managing cash flows. I gained confidence in ensuring that financial data is accurate, complete, and well-organized for decision-making purposes.

B**ank reconciliation and analytical skills** were improved by regularly comparing ledger balances with bank statements, identifying discrepancies, and making necessary adjustments. This enhanced my attention to detail, critical thinking, and problem-solving abilities, which are crucial for accurate financial reporting and internal control.

I enhanced **communication and interpersonal skills** through interactions with colleagues, suppliers, and customers while settling debts and verifying invoices. These tasks required clear communication, negotiation, and professional etiquette, which are valuable for maintaining good business relationships.

Time management and organizational skills were developed by performing multiple accounting tasks simultaneously and meeting deadlines for reconciliations, reports, and payments. I learned to prioritize tasks effectively and manage workload efficiently, which improved overall productivity.

I gained **practical application of accounting theories and software skills**, linking classroom knowledge to real-world operations. Using accounting tools and observing internal control procedures allowed me to apply theoretical concepts, such as Stewardship Theory and Internal Control Theory, to enhance accuracy, reliability, and ethical financial management practices.

FIELD REPORT SAMPLE

4.4. Review of how the experience has affected your career plans and ambitions

The field practical training has significantly influenced my career plans and ambitions by providing hands-on exposure to real-world accounting and financial management practices. Experiencing tasks such as preparing journals, recording sales transactions, settling debts, and performing bank reconciliations allowed me to understand the practical demands and responsibilities of an accounting professional. This exposure has reinforced my interest in pursuing a career in accounting and finance, particularly in areas related to auditing, financial analysis, and internal controls.

The experience highlighted the importance of accuracy, ethical practices, and attention to detail in financial management. Observing how organizations implement internal controls, manage cash flows, and reconcile accounts has motivated me to aim for positions that emphasize accountability, risk management, and financial integrity. It has also strengthened my ambition to specialize in financial management systems and automation to improve efficiency and decision-making in organizations.

The practical exposure has also influenced my long-term career goals by showing the value of continuous learning and adaptation to technological advancements. Tasks involving digital accounting tools, record-keeping, and reconciliation demonstrated how technology enhances efficiency and accuracy, encouraging me to develop strong software and analytical skills for future career growth.

Interacting with professionals in the accounts department has inspired me to develop strong interpersonal and communication skills, which are essential for teamwork, client relations, and professional advancement. The experience has motivated me to pursue professional certifications and training to enhance my qualifications and career prospects in the accounting field.

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4.5Skills that are lacking

Advanced Accounting Software Proficiency

Upon joining the organization, I realized that my knowledge of advanced accounting software such as SAP and Tally was limited. While I could perform basic entries, I lacked the ability to fully utilize features like automated reconciliation and complex reporting. This gap slowed some processes and highlighted the need for further training. Improving proficiency in these tools will enhance efficiency and accuracy in financial management.

Taxation and Compliance Knowledge

I observed that handling tax computations, VAT submissions, and compliance reporting required deeper knowledge than I currently possess. Although I understood the theoretical concepts from class, applying them in real-life scenarios was challenging. Strengthening this skill is essential for ensuring legal compliance and accurate financial reporting. Developing practical tax skills will make me more competent in accounting roles.

Financial Analysis and Forecasting

I found that my ability to analyze financial statements, prepare forecasts, and interpret cash flow trends was limited. While I could record transactions accurately, making informed recommendations based on data was challenging. This skill is crucial for strategic decision-making and advising management. Enhancing analytical skills will help in providing actionable insights in financial operations.

Time Management Under Workload Pressure

Managing multiple tasks simultaneously, such as reconciling accounts, recording sales, and settling debts, revealed that my time management skills under pressure could be improved. At times, prioritizing tasks was difficult, affecting efficiency. Developing better planning and scheduling techniques will improve productivity and workflow management.

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Communication and Report Writing

Although I interacted with staff and clients, I realized that my professional communication, especially in report writing and presenting financial findings, needed improvement. Clear, concise, and structured reporting is critical for conveying financial information to management. Strengthening these skills will improve my effectiveness in conveying insights and recommendations.

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CHAPTER FIVE

CONCLUSION AND RECOMMENDATIONS

5.1. Chapter Introduction

This chapter presents the summary, conclusions, and recommendations based on the field practical training and the findings from the tasks undertaken in the accounts department. It provides an overview of the skills learned, challenges encountered, and how the experience has influenced my career plans. The chapter also highlights areas for improvement, both for the organization and for personal professional development. It offers actionable recommendations to East Africa Food and the Institute/IFM to enhance practical training outcomes and align theoretical knowledge with industry practices.

5.2. Conclusion

In conclusion, the field practical training provided valuable exposure to real-world accounting and financial management practices, bridging the gap between theoretical knowledge and practical application. Through tasks such as preparing journals, recording sales transactions, settling debts, and performing bank reconciliations, I developed essential skills in bookkeeping, analytical thinking, and internal control. The experience enhanced my understanding of financial accuracy, accountability, and ethical management. It also revealed areas where further skill development is needed, such as advanced software proficiency and financial analysis. Observing market practices highlighted the importance of adapting classroom theories to practical realities. Overall, the training has strengthened my career ambitions and provided a solid foundation for professional growth in the accounting field.

5.3. Recommendations

5.3.1. Recommendations to the East African Food

East Africa Food should continue investing in modern technology for accounting, inventory management, and distribution processes. Implementing advanced accounting software and automated reconciliation systems can improve accuracy, reduce errors, and save time in financial reporting. This will enhance operational efficiency and allow management to make more informed decisions based on real-time data.

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Secondly, the company should provide regular training and capacity-building programs for employees, focusing on both technical skills and soft skills. This includes training in advanced accounting tools, financial analysis, customer service, and communication. By equipping staff with these skills, the company can improve productivity, reduce operational errors, and strengthen customer and supplier relationships.

East Africa Food should consider strengthening its internal control systems and monitoring mechanisms. Regular audits, periodic checks, and clear accountability structures will help prevent discrepancies, enhance transparency, and safeguard company assets. Strengthening these controls will also ensure that best practices in financial management and ethical operations are consistently followed, promoting trust and sustainability in the business.

5.3.2. Recommendations to the institute/IFM

Firstly, IFM should strengthen the integration of practical training into the curriculum by collaborating more closely with industry partners. This will ensure that students gain hands-on experience relevant to current market practices, bridging the gap between theory and real-world application.

Secondly, the institute should organize regular workshops and short courses on modern accounting software, financial analysis, and emerging trends in business management. This will enhance students' technical competencies and prepare them for the evolving demands of the workplace.

Finally, IFM should establish mentorship and feedback mechanisms during field attachments. Regular monitoring and guidance from both academic supervisors and industry mentors will help students maximize learning outcomes, address challenges effectively, and develop professional skills necessary for successful careers in accounting and finance.

FIELD REPORT SAMPLE

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